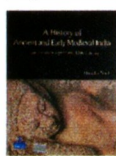


THE PANORAMIC PAST

This riveting journey through many millennia of Indian story is not guided by any ideology or agenda



A HISTORY OF ANCIENT AND EARLY MEDIEVAL INDIA: FROM THE STONE AGE TO THE 12TH CENTURY

by UPINDER SINGH
Pearson Longman

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■ By Nayanjot Lahiri

The history of India has been written in many ways. If there are books that study the small things that are so often overlooked, there are also works that map out large grids of time and space. Upinder Singh's new book combines these perspectives. From the first stone tools of the Siwaliks to the sumptuous stone temples of Tanjavur, from the Rgvedic Agni to the medieval woman-saint Andal, Singh tells the entire story of ancient and early medieval India in a single volume. Simultaneously, and this is what makes it a tremendous read. She inserts into this vast landscape a degree of magnification which brings alive ordinary artifacts and unknown people.

The book's originality, first of all, lies in its arrangement and presentation. This is the first work on ancient India where the text has been constructed at different levels. Ten chapters pan across the whole canvas, from prehistory and protohistory to ancient and early medieval history. The panorama is interspersed with inset capsules where some themes are picked out to illustrate larger elements in the chapters. The capsules, of which there are more than 150, perform several functions. They draw attention to a variety of topics which otherwise would find no place in a synthetic history. They concern methods of study such as dating techniques in archaeology, questions of terminology

such as defining a state, demystification of technicalities such as how ancient eras are converted into modern dates, and the widest possible scatter of sites in different periods and parts of India.

Equally important is that these capsules illustrate activities which are usually considered to be too inconsequential to figure in mainstream works of history. Think, for instance, of the thousands whose death is remembered on memorial stones. We usually hear of those set up in the memory of heroic kings and soldiers. Here, we also learn about hero stones recording the death of women including a queen who organised a cattle raid. And, there are memorial stones through which we

ENGRAVED IN TIME: A late first-century sculpture of the Buddha



know the names of pets—Punisha, a hunting dog, who died killing a wild boar and Kali, the dog who was also killed during a hunt. The most unusual is a 12th-century epigraph which mourns the pet parrot of a Kadamba king. When the parrot was eaten by a cat in the palace, the king killed himself in grief! Or take the more engaging world of lovers and courtesans. The famous protagonist of Kalidasa's *Meghaduta*—a banished yaksha longing for his beloved—and the manner in which he pleads with a passing cloud to carry his message to the land of his beloved is feelingly described. As evocative, though less known, is the intense longing woven into an inscription—a capsule captures this love story—at the Jogimara cave in Chhattisgarh. Resembling modern lovely graffiti, it was inscribed by the sculptor Devadinna for the devadasi Sutanuka because Devadinna

"loved her". Or consider the mundane foodways of early India. Information about different kinds of meats, fruits, cereals and so much else is provided, and sometimes used to ask larger questions. The presence of custard apple seeds at Sanghol (Punjab) in the early centuries A.D., for instance, is used to challenge the general belief that it was introduced into India in the 16th century by the Portuguese. In fact, Singh's deep affection for all kinds of ancient Indians has ensured that even as she takes us on a journey through many millennia of events and trends about societies and cultures, she does not lose sight of ordinary people, or for that matter, their eating habits, or even their pets.

Early India is not merely humanised through such capsules and sources,